would affect India's relations with Iran. Even after Indian prime minister Narendra Modi's highly publicized visit to Israel in July 2017, and even though India today is the second-largest client of the Israeli defense industries, Indian spokespeople advise Israel that, rather than exhibiting hostility toward the Iranian regime, it is preferable to show sympathy for the Iranian people. These spokespeople either ignore or are not aware of the complete hold that the regime has over the people of Iran, thanks in part to the IRGC, which is now the central force in the country, controlling the army, nonconventional weapons, the economy, and, to a greater and greater extent, the ayatollahs. It is the IRGC that is exhibiting hostility toward Israel.

The informal assessment of the US State Department was that engagement with Iran would not yield a satisfactory agreement on Iran's nuclear program but that if an agreement were to be reached it would postpone the final product and allow Iran to continue accumulating low-enriched uranium until a decision was made regarding a breakout (that is, a declaration and/or an experiment). The thinking was that gaining more time was preferable to having an immediate confrontation. However, disagreements on the question of Iran arose between Secretary of State Hillary Clinton and the White House, with Clinton demanding a tougher approach and the setting of a timetable for negotiations, as well as open expressions of support for the Iranian opposition. She argued that it was impossible to negotiate only with carrots and with no stick. It became more and more apparent that the administration could not adhere to red lines in relation to Iran's nuclear program, even though both the White House and the State Department knew that it was impossible to conduct negotiations with no limits. Period!

The claim that the United States was too biased when it came to Israel, to the point of any criticism against Israel being considered illegitimate, was increasingly heard both within the Democratic Party and within the administration, at least until President Trump took office in early 2017. Many American officials grew tired of hearing Israel's argument that a nuclear Iran was an existential threat and adopted the view that the Iranians were rational and therefore would not use nuclear weapons against Israel, if and when they had them. This assessment is very dangerous and far-reaching if one remembers that what is being discussed is the possibility of a nuclear event, with the decision maker being the spiritual leader who,